

the 40 Ratna recipients, more than half are politicians, the name of the award should be changed to Neta Ratna.
GURPREET SANDHU, *on e-mail*

Ideally, the Ratna should be awarded to someone whose photograph can be proudly displayed in a common man's drawing room.

UMESH S. SHUKLA, *Ahmedabad*

Political parties are making a mockery of the Bharat Ratna. It should be put in cold storage for an indefinite period.

HARISCHANDRA PARASURAM, *Mumbai*

If the father of the nation has not been conferred the honour, there is no justification behind others to be given this award. Let it be given to any Indian who has done yeoman service for the country.

RODA D. HAKIM, *on e-mail*

Unnecessary politicisation of awards will only reduce their prestige. People will continue to hold great leaders in high esteem irrespective of such honours.

P. PRASAND THAMPY, *Thiruvalla*

Ignorant Class

Jyoti Basu's statement that Marxists seek to achieve socialism to usher in a classless society is amusing (Voices, January 28). What they ignore is that classes exist in every field—there is a ruling class and a non-ruling class, intellectual class and non-intellectual class. A Polish philosopher had rightly said: "Socialism is a fried snowball". Only the crooked Marxists swear by it to fool the people.

ASOKE C. BANERJEE, *Kolkata*

Negotiating with the Dragon

One can only hope that the Sino-Indian amity is not like "Made in China" goods that last only till the shopper leaves the shop ("Breaching the Great Wall", January 28).

RAJNEESH BATRA, *Delhi*

Peace Makers

Islam has been maligned a lot in India and in other parts of the world ("The Corridor of Peace", January 28). But this step by the

Sufis will go a long way in improving its image. The effort deserves success.

SHEILA RAJKUMAR, *Chennai*

Correction

In the article "The Down Syndrome" (February 4), we wrongly mentioned that the field work for the Mood of the Nation Poll was done between December 26, 2006 and January 9, 2007. It was done between December 26, 2007 and January 17, 2008. The error is regretted.

SMALL WONDER



The manner in which the magazine has covered the entry of Tata's Nano makes me proud of being a citizen of a country where not only technology, but the quality of journalism has reached dizzying heights too ("Ratan's Revolution", January 21).

SUMANLATHA G., *Visakhapatnam*

Ratan Tata's grit deserves a standing ovation. However, in trying to build the cheapest car, he has compromised on the safety standards just like Maruti Omni—both have a rear engine. I wish Tata does something about that.

A.S. RAJ, *on e-mail*

Those who say that the Nano will add to the congestion on the roads would do well to remember that everyone has an equal right to drive. As far as poor infrastructure is concerned, it is the government's problem.

RAJIV CHOPRA, *Dehradun*

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Years Ago in India Today

FEBRUARY 16-28, 1978



Strange Bedfellows

Politics and film stars make the oddest of bedfellows.

Tamil Nadu's M.G.

Ramachandran (MGR) better known for his swashbuckling antics on the screen than his performance on the political stage, has now rudely rocked the cradle that nurtured him. MGR recently issued a stern

warning to the south Indian

film industry to curtail their headlong rush

to introduce

MGR

"kissing scenes" in films. "It is an insult to the Tamilian

culture," MGR declared at a

function to honour artists of the stage and screen. Tamil

film producers are understandably piqued at his sudden

attack of pious preaching. They point out that MGR him-

self willingly submitted to the amorous advances of his co-

stars, and anti-kissing stand is nothing more than a political

stunt. He, however, encouraged by the highly conserva-

tive Tamil public's support for his anti-kissing crusade, is

bent on playing to the gallery.

—**Deep Bobb with G.V. Rama Rao**